

THE 90-DAY HABIT SYSTEM



A HIGH-PERFORMANCE FRAMEWORK FOR EXECUTIVE
FUNCTION & PRODUCTIVITY

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THE 90-DAY HABIT SYSTEM

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THE 90-DAY HABIT SYSTEM

Status: Active



Start here if you want to begin today → Jump to Quick Start Guide below and do your first two-minute habit now. Read the rest later.



Bold ideas, tiny actions. Skim the callouts, check the visuals, then dive in where you feel momentum.

QUICK START: READ THIS FIRST

 **Your goal for the next 7 days:** pick one keystone habit and do the **two-minute version** daily.

How it works

1. **Anchor** it to a cue you already do: "After I make coffee..."
2. **Do** the two-minute version: one push-up, one page, one transaction, or a two-minute tidy.
3. **Reward** it so you feel the win: playlist, tea, big ✓ on a wall tracker.
4. **Fallback:** "If I miss the morning, I'll do the 60-second version after lunch."
5. **Rule:**  **Never zero twice.** ← Your one universal rule

 **When you miss (because you will): The GBOT Protocol** 1. **Name it:** "I missed because of X" (no judgment) 2. **Return to base:** Do the 2-minute version immediately 3. **Patch the leak:** What broke the loop? Time? Cue? Environment? 4. **Create if-then:** "If [situation], then [minimum version]"

Week-1 checklist

- ☐ Cue chosen and written where it happens
- ☐ Tools placed at the cue (book on pillow, shoes by kettle)
- ☐ Two-minute version defined
- ☐ Felt reward decided
- ☐ Fallback written and practiced once

What to expect

- Days 1–3: clunky but doable
- Days 4–7: less negotiation and small pride

 **If you wobble: shrink, don't restart**

FIRST 24 HOURS: YOUR MICRO-GUIDE



Get started right now—no planning paralysis.

Today (Day 0): Design your loop

1. Pick ONE habit: _
2. Choose your cue: After I _, I will...
3. Define the 2-minute version: _
4. Pick your reward: _
5. Place your tools where the cue happens (now, not tomorrow)

Tomorrow morning (Day 1): Execute once

- When the cue fires, do the 2-minute version
- Immediately follow with your reward
- Mark a checkmark somewhere visible

Tomorrow evening (Day 1): 60-second reflection

- Did I do it? Yes / No
- If yes: What made it easy?
- If no: What got in the way? (Fix this before Day 2)

That's it. You're now in the system.

CHOOSE YOUR PATH

 Which path fits you best?

Path A: Beginner

Never stuck to a habit for more than a week

- Start with Chapter 1
- Follow the program exactly
- Don't skip the 2-minute rule
- Focus on ONE habit only

Path B: Experienced

Built habits before, but they faded

- Skim Chapters 1-2
- Deep-dive Chapter 7 (Foundation Complete)
- Focus on maintenance from Day 1
- Build your if-then plans early

Path C: Recovery

Had a habit, lost it, want it back

- Read Chapter 9 first (GBOT Protocol)
- Return to your last working version
- Identify what broke the loop
- Rebuild with better guardrails

INTRODUCTION – WHY MOST HABIT CHANGES FAIL

Ninety-two percent of New Year's resolutions fizzle by February—not because people are lazy, but because they use sprint rules for a season-length game. Willpower can start a habit; only design can keep it.

>

 **Brain fact:** Habits run on cue → behaviour → reward loops in the basal ganglia. Design beats willpower.

If you've ever sworn "this time I'll stick to it" and then slipped a week later, you're not broken—you're using the wrong playbook.

Most advice treats habits like willpower contests. Push harder. Try again. That works for a sprint, not for a season.

Real change is less about force and more about design.

HERE'S WHY CHANGE OFTEN STALLS:

- **Too big, too fast.** We leap to hour-long workouts, perfect diets, and daily journaling. The brain resists sharp jumps in effort, so motivation spikes... then crashes.
- **Vague goals.** "Be healthier" and "save more" sound inspiring but give your brain no clear next action.
- **No trigger.** If a behaviour isn't tied to a cue (time, place, emotion), it has nowhere to live in your day.
- **Hostile environment.** The biscuit tin beside the kettle beats your 6 a.m. resolve every time.
- **All-or-nothing thinking.** One miss becomes "I've failed," and the habit gets binned instead of resumed.

 **Loop in a glance:** | Element | What to design | Example | | --- | --- | --- | | Cue | Time / place / action | After coffee | | Behaviour | Lowest viable action | 1 push-up | | Reward | Felt win | Playlist + ✓ |

Under the hood, habits run on a loop: **cue** → **behaviour** → **reward**.

Cues light up patterns in the **basal ganglia**, the brain's autopilot centre. Each repetition lays myelin—think insulation—over that circuit, making it faster and easier to fire next time.

Rewards release a little dopamine, which tags the loop as "worth repeating." Willpower sits in the prefrontal cortex and tires quickly; well-built loops barely touch it.

So our job isn't to "be stronger." It's to **engineer loops** that are small, obvious, and rewarding—then repeat them until they become the default.

THE 90-DAY GAME PLAN

🔗 **Three phases to lasting change:** 1. Design small, obvious loops 2. Build with gentle ladders 3. Lock in with identity + environment

🎯 **Phase promise at a glance:** - **By Day 30** you will have a loop that fires most days without argument - **By Day 60** you will have survived real disruptions and bounced back fast - **By Day 90** you will own a new identity: "I am someone who ____"

This book gives you a 90-day, evidence-based way to do exactly that. Instead of a burst of enthusiasm followed by guilt, you'll move through three clear phases:

Days 1–30: Design

Shrink each habit to the "lowest viable action" (two push-ups, one minute of budgeting).

Anchor it to a strong cue you already have (after coffee, after school drop-off).

Choose a friction-cutting environment (shoes by the door, fruit on the bench).

Days 31–60: Build

Gradually scale with **habit ladders**—tiny, planned increases.

Track with simple yes/no checkmarks.

Use **temptation bundling** (habit + something you enjoy) to keep dopamine on your side.

Days 61–90: Lock-in

Add **if-then plans** for disruptions ("If I miss the morning, I'll do the two-minute version at lunch").

Introduce small variability to make the habit resilient across contexts.

Review weekly to fix bottlenecks, not yourself.

🔧 **Behaviour-first, identity-backed** Let small actions prove the story you want.

📊 **Systems over streaks** Rule: **never zero twice**.

🏠 **Environment as coach** Make the right action the easy action.

By the end, you won't be relying on motivation. You'll have a handful of quiet, automatic behaviours that stack into visible change—fitter, calmer, more in control of your time and money.

Ninety days from now, you won't just feel different. You'll **be** different, because your days will run on better loops.

PROGRESS MILESTONES: WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

Day	**Milestone**	**What It Feels Like**	**Key Metric**
7	First full week	Clunky but showing up	5-7 days completed
14	Survived the novelty fade	Less negotiation	10+ days total, ease rating climbing
21	Crossed the "feeling" threshold	Starting to feel automatic	Ease rating 3+ most days
30	Foundation locked in	Identity shift beginning	24+ days, survived first dip
45	Built resilience through variation	Works in 2+ contexts	36+ days, habit chain active
60	Integration complete	Survived real disruption	48+ days, recovered from setback
75	Identity fully wired	"This is who I am"	60+ days, effortless most days
90	Full mastery	Automatic, portable, resilient	72+ days, ready for maintenance

PART ONE: FOUNDATION (DAYS 1–30)

 **You are here: Days 1–30** Goal: Install a reliable loop that fires most days without argument.

CHAPTER 1 — THE 90-DAY FRAMEWORK

 Change sticks when your brain, your calendar, and your environment all agree. Think **season**, not sprint.

WHY 90 DAYS?

There isn't a single "magic number" for everyone, but 90 days balances three realities:

1. Neural change needs cycles, not moments.

Each repetition lays down or strengthens pathways in the brain (neuroplasticity). Early gains are fragile; they consolidate with sleep and spaced repetition over weeks.

Roughly three months gives you enough cycles for a behaviour to move from conscious effort to semi-automatic.

2. Life variability tests the habit.

In 90 days you'll face at least a few disruptions—travel, illness, deadlines, school holidays. A habit that survives those tests is a habit that lasts.

Thirty days rarely includes enough variability; ninety almost guarantees it.

3. Motivation curves are predictable.

Most people feel a motivational dip around weeks 3–5 and another at weeks 8–10. Planning for both within one program keeps you from mislabeling a normal dip as failure.

Think of 90 days as a complete season: **design** → **build** → **lock in**.

THE BRAIN BASICS (QUICK AND HUMAN)

Habits run on a loop: **cue** → **behaviour** → **reward**.

- **Cue:** a signal (time, place, emotion, preceding action).
- **Behaviour:** what you do.
- **Reward:** a payoff that tells your brain "repeat this."

🧠 **Basal ganglia** = autopilot. **Dopamine** = "remember this." **Prefrontal** = tires quickly. Design loops to spare willpower.

Cues and routines are coordinated by the **basal ganglia**—your autopilot. Rewards pulse **dopamine**, which tags the loop as "worth it."

Early on, your **prefrontal cortex** (planning, willpower) does the heavy lifting. With practice, the prefrontal load drops; the basal ganglia take over. That's why established habits feel "effortless."

Neuroplasticity—the brain's ability to rewire—drives the shift.

Repetition plus reward strengthens connections; inconsistent reps or ambiguous rewards stall them. Sleep helps consolidate the changes; stress and fatigue can temporarily weaken access to the new routine, which is why we design fallback versions ("two-minute mode") for hard days.



Key takeaways: - Design strong **cues** and consistent **rewards** - Keep early behaviours **tiny** to survive low-energy days - Expect dips; they are wiring, not weakness

THE 90-DAY FRAMEWORK AT A GLANCE

Phase	**Goal**	**Tools**	**Scoreboard**	**Pitfalls Fixed**
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(Days 1–30) | Map & Simplify | Habit Loop Map

2-Min Rule | Daily Checkmark | Too Big,

Vague Goals |

(Days 31–60) | Consistency & Adaptation | Habit Stacking,

GBOT Protocol | Weekly Trends | No Trigger,

Hostile Environment |

(Days 61–90) | Identity + Resilience | Identity Ritual

Env. Upgrades | Effortless Days | All-or-Nothing |

Phase 1: **Foundation (Days 1–30) — *Make it do-able and obvious***

 **By Day 30 you will:** have a loop that fires most days without negotiation, and the identity "I am someone who ____" will start to feel true.

Goal: Install a reliable loop that fires most days without argument.

How:

- **Lowest Viable Action (LVA):** Shrink the habit until it's almost silly. One push-up. One minute of budgeting. One line in a journal. LVA builds consistency and reduces friction.
- **Anchor to an existing cue:** "After I make coffee...", "After school drop-off...", "After I open my laptop..."
- **Shape the environment:** Put the kettlebell by the kettle. Put fruit at eye level. Block distracting sites during the target window.
- **Immediate reward:** Pair the habit with something pleasant—favourite playlist, a tick on a visible tracker, a tiny square of chocolate after the walk.

Scoreboard: Aim for **80–90% days** with simple yes/no checks.

Phase 2: ****Integration**** (Days 31–60) — ***Make it fit your real life***

 **By Day 60 you will:** have survived at least 2 real disruptions (travel, illness, deadlines) and recovered fast using the GBOT Protocol.

Goal: Build consistency through disruption and expand your habit ecosystem.

How:

- **Habit laddering** with small increases (add 1 minute per week, or 1 rep per session)
- **Context rehearsal** in two places (home and work, morning and evening)
- **If-then planning** ("If I miss morning, then lunch version")
- **Temptation bundling** (favourite podcast only during the habit)

Scoreboard: Track **weekly averages** and ease ratings (1-5 scale).

Phase 3: ****Mastery**** (Days 61–90) — ***Make it resilient and identity-level***

 **By Day 90 you will:** own a new identity that runs on autopilot across multiple contexts. The habit is you now.

Goal: Shift from "doing" to "being" — make the habit part of who you are.

How:

- **Identity statements** ("I am someone who moves daily")
- Weekly 15-min reviews with snapshot + keep/change/kill decisions
- **Slight variability** to prevent boredom and build adaptability
- **Automated supports** (calendar blocks, auto-reminders, environment upgrades)
- **Portability planning** for travel and life changes

Scoreboard: Count **effortless days** where the habit happens with zero negotiation.

WHAT "SCIENTIFICALLY OPTIMAL" REALLY MEANS

"Optimal" here is practical: enough reps, spacing, sleep, stress tests, and feedback loops.

 **Research-backed checklist:** ✓ Sufficient repetitions (60-90 cycles) ✓ Spaced practice with rest days ✓ Real-world stress tests (travel, illness, deadlines) ✓ Weekly reflection and adjustment loops

SETTING EXPECTATIONS (SO YOU DON'T SELF-SABOTAGE)

Common Myth	**Reality**
I should do it perfectly from day 1	Clunky is normal. You're building new neural pathways.
If I miss once, I've failed	**Never zero twice.** One miss is data, two is a pattern.
It should feel easier immediately	Weeks 3-5 are typically the hardest. Design carries you through.
Small habits are cheating	Small is the only way to build the runway for big.
Progress is linear	Expect plateaus. Consistency compounds invisibly before it shows.

⚠ The real failure modes: - Starting too big and burning out by week 2 - No fallback plan for disruptions - Tracking perfection instead of consistency - Ignoring environment design

YOUR TOOLS IN THIS BOOK

- **Design sheets** for cues, environments, if-then plans
- **Weekly reviews** (15-minute debrief template)
- **Two-minute fallbacks** for every habit
- **Checklists and trackers** (simple yes/no, no complex logging)
- **Identity rituals** to lock in your new self-story

A SAMPLE 90-DAY ARC (FITNESS EXAMPLE)

Days	**Action**	**Key Tool**
1–7	After coffee, put on shoes and do 1 min of squats. Mark ✓ on wall calendar. Reward: favourite track.	LVA + Cue Anchor
8–30	Ladder to 3–5 minutes. Add if–then: "If mornings explode, 2 min before lunch." Shoes live by kettle.	Habit Laddering + Environment
31–45	Try lunchtime version at work 2x/week. Spare trainers under desk. Add short walk after.	Context Rehearsal
46–60	Ladder to 8–10 min on 3 days, keep 2-min fallback on rest. Track minutes, not perfection.	Flexibility + Tracking
61–75	Alternate circuits and walks. Identity card on fridge: "I move daily." Weekly 15-min review Sundays.	Identity Ritual + Variability
76–90	Automate: calendar block, playlist, recurring reminder for worn socks. Celebrate non-scale wins.	Automation + Celebration

WHAT YOU'LL FEEL ALONG THE WAY

Weeks 1–2

Friction dropping. You're learning the dance steps. Some internal negotiation, but you're showing up.

Weeks 3–5

Motivation dip. This is where most people quit. Rely on cues, LVA, and bundling to carry you through.

Weeks 6–8

Ease appears. You stop thinking so hard about whether to do it. The loop is wiring in.

Weeks 9–12

Ownership. You protect the habit because it represents you now. It's part of your identity.

HOW WE'LL MEASURE SUCCESS

 **Three metrics that matter:** 1. **Consistency** — % of days completed (target: 80%+) 2. **Capacity** — gradual increase in duration or intensity 3. **Resilience** — habit survives at least 2 disruptions (travel, illness, etc.)



Chapter 1 Key Takeaways: - 90 days = enough cycles for neuroplasticity + life variability + motivation dips - Habits run on cue → behaviour → reward loops in the basal ganglia - Three phases: Design (1-30) → Build (31-60) → Lock-in (61-90) - Success = 80%+ consistency, gradual capacity growth, and resilience through disruption

***Up next:** Now that you understand the framework, Chapter 2 breaks down exactly how to map your existing habits and design new ones from scratch. You'll learn the four types of cues and how to engineer loops that stick.*

>

CHAPTER 2 — UNDERSTANDING YOUR HABIT ARCHITECTURE



Habits aren't character traits. They're loops. When you can see the loop, you can change it.

Every behaviour that repeats follows the same simple pattern. Understanding this architecture gives you the blueprint for building new habits and dismantling old ones.

THE ANATOMY OF A HABIT LOOP

At the simplest level, every habit follows a three-part pattern:

- **Cue** → the trigger that tells your brain, "Now."
- **Routine** → the behaviour you do.
- **Reward** → the payoff that teaches your brain, "Do this again."



Relatable example — The 3 p.m. snack loop - **Cue:** 3:00 energy dip - **Routine:** biscuits from the pantry - **Reward:** sugar rush + break from work + dopamine hit

The loop becomes automatic because the reward is satisfying *and* immediate. Your brain tags it: "Next time we feel this cue, do this routine."

THE FOUR TYPES OF CUES

Most cues fall into one of four categories:

Cue Type	**Examples**	**Design Strategy**
Time	7:00 AM, lunch break, bedtime	Set a recurring alarm or use an existing time anchor
Place	Kitchen, gym, car, desk	Leave tools/reminders in that location
Emotion	Stress, boredom, anxiety, excitement	Create if-then plan: "When I feel X, I will Y"
Preceding Action	After coffee, after brushing teeth, after opening laptop	**Habit stacking** — attach new habit to existing routine

The most reliable cues are time + place combinations. "After I make coffee in the kitchen" is stronger than just "morning" or just "kitchen."

CRAVING: THE HIDDEN ENGINE

Between cue and routine sits a crucial element: **craving**.

The cue doesn't just trigger the routine—it triggers the *anticipation* of the reward. That anticipation is what pulls you forward.

Bad habit example:

Cue: Phone buzzes

Craving: Novelty, connection

Routine: Check social media

Reward: Dopamine hit

Good habit example:

Cue: Kettle whistles

Craving: Energy, calm

Routine: 2-min stretch

Reward: Loose muscles + clarity

💡 **Design move:** To build a new habit, make the craving obvious and appealing. To break a bad habit, make the craving unappealing or replace the routine while keeping the same reward.

THE REWARD LIBRARY: WHAT ACTUALLY WORKS

Rewards must be **immediate** and **felt**. Here's a menu organized by type:

Reward Type	**Examples**	**Best For**
Physical	Stretch, cold water, sunlight, hot shower	Morning routines, post-workout
Sensory	Favorite song, scented candle, soft blanket	Evening wind-down, meditation
Social	Text accountability partner, share progress, high-five	Long-term habits, milestones
Consumable	Special coffee, piece of chocolate, herbal tea	Daily habits, small wins
Digital	One episode, favorite podcast, game level	Temptation bundling only
Progress	Checkmark on calendar, streak counter, photo	Visual motivation, consistency tracking



Pro tip: Stack rewards. Check calendar (progress) + play song (sensory) + text friend (social) = triple dopamine hit.

RESCRIPTING A LOOP: THE SWAP METHOD

You can't delete a habit loop—the cue-reward connection stays wired. But you *can* swap the routine in the middle.

OLD LOOP

Cue: 3 PM, hunger pangs

Routine: Biscuits from pantry

Reward: Sugar rush & comfort

NEW LOOP

Cue: 3 PM, hunger pangs

Routine: Walk + sparkling water

Reward: Fresh air & clarity

 **Strategy:** Keep the cue. Swap the routine. Match the reward type (if old reward was "break," new reward should also provide a break).

BUILDING VS. BREAKING: QUICK REFERENCE

	Building a New Habit	**Breaking a Bad Habit**
Cue	Make it obvious (visual reminders, alarms)	Make it invisible (remove triggers)
Craving	Make it attractive (bundle with enjoyment)	Make it unattractive (pair with cost)
Routine	Make it easy (reduce to 2 minutes)	Make it difficult (add friction)
Reward	Make it satisfying (immediate + felt)	Make it unsatisfying (track the cost)

WORKSHOP: MAP YOUR CURRENT LOOP

Pick one habit you want to change (build or break). Fill in the loop:

Cue (when/where/what triggers it?):

Craving (what do you actually want?):

Routine (what do you do?):

Reward (what payoff do you get?):

 **Next step:** - If building: Design the smallest possible routine and pair it with an immediate reward - If breaking: Identify the real reward you're after, then find a healthier routine that delivers it



Chapter 2 Key Takeaways: - Every habit follows: Cue → (Craving) → Routine → Reward - Four cue types: Time, Place, Emotion, Preceding Action - You can't delete a loop, but you can swap the routine - To build: make obvious, attractive, easy, satisfying - To break: make invisible, unattractive, difficult, unsatisfying

***Up next:** You understand the loop. Now Chapter 3 shows you how to make the loop so small it's impossible to resist—the 2-minute rule that removes all negotiation.*

>

CHAPTER 3 — THE POWER OF MICRO-COMMITMENTS

 **2-Minute Rule:** Make the first version so small you can't say no.

The biggest mistake people make with habits is starting too big.

Your brain treats big commitments as threats. Small commitments slip past resistance.

WHY "JUST DO TWO MINUTES" WORKS

When you shrink a habit to two minutes, you accomplish three things:

1. You remove negotiation.

There's no mental back-and-forth about whether you have time or energy. Two minutes? You always have two minutes.

2. You build the neural pathway.

The first 30 days aren't about results—they're about wiring. Every rep strengthens the loop, no matter how small.

3. You prove the identity.

"I am someone who exercises daily" is true whether you do 2 minutes or 20. The identity forms from consistency, not intensity.

THE 2-MINUTE VERSIONS OF COMMON HABITS

Big Goal	**2-Minute Version**	**Why It Works**
Exercise daily	Put on workout shoes + 1 push-up	Gets you to the starting line; momentum takes over
Read more books	Read 1 page	Opens the book; you often keep going
Meditate daily	Sit on cushion + 3 breaths	Establishes the ritual anchor
Write a book	Write 1 sentence	Defeats blank-page paralysis
Healthy eating	Eat 1 piece of fruit	Builds the "healthy choice" muscle
Learn a language	Practice 1 flashcard	Maintains the daily touchpoint

THE GATEWAY EFFECT

Here's the secret: two minutes is the *entry point*.

Most days, you'll do more once you've started. But even if you don't—even if you stop at exactly two minutes—you've still won. You've cast a vote for your new identity.

■ **Gateway principle:** The habit of showing up is more valuable than the habit of perfection.

🎯 **Real example:** "Put on running shoes" leads to a 5K run 60% of the time. But even when it doesn't, the loop still fires.

BEATING PERFECTIONISM WITH THE "GOOD ENOUGH" LINE

One of the biggest habit killers is perfectionism. If you can't do the "proper" version, you skip it entirely.

The two-minute rule gives you a floor, not a ceiling.

Level	**Definition**	**Example: Daily Movement**
Minimum (2-min)	The floor. You <i>*always*</i> do this.	Put on shoes + 1 push-up
Target (10-min)	Your default on normal days.	10-minute body-weight circuit
Ideal (30-min)	When energy and time align.	Full gym session or long run



Rule: On hard days, hit the minimum. On normal days, hit the target. On great days, go ideal. **Never zero.**

CASE STUDY: MAYA'S MORNING PAGES

 **Background:** Maya, a freelance designer, wanted to journal daily to process anxiety and generate creative ideas.

First attempt: 30 minutes of morning pages, inspired by "The Artist's Way." Lasted 4 days. Felt overwhelming, mornings too rushed. **The adjustment:** Shrunk to **one sentence** after her first coffee. "Today I feel ***and I want to*** ." **What**

happened: - Week 1: Hit 6/7 days. Felt silly but doable. - Week 3: Naturally expanded to 3-4 sentences most days. -

Week 8: Writing a full page 4x/week, but still counts one sentence as a win. - Day 90: Journaling became her non-

negotiable. Generated 3 client projects from insights in her pages. **Key insight:** "I thought starting small was cheating.

But the one-sentence version proved I was a daily writer. Once that identity was real, the volume followed."

MICRO-COMMITMENT MENU

Choose **one** habit to build. Write out the three levels:

Habit: ____

Minimum (2-min): ____

Target (10-min): ____

Ideal (30-min): ____

Cue anchor: After I __, I will do the minimum version.

COMMON TRAPS & HOW TO AVOID THEM

⚠ **Trap 1: "Two minutes won't make a difference"** → Wrong frame. The goal in Phase 1 is to build the loop, not the outcome. Consistency first, intensity later. **Trap 2: "I'll just do more from day 1"** → You'll burn out by week 2. Trust the ladder. Start small. **Trap 3: "I did two minutes, but I feel guilty for not doing more"** → Two minutes is a **win**, not a compromise. Celebrate it. You cast a vote.



Chapter 3 Key Takeaways: - The 2-minute rule removes negotiation and builds the neural pathway - Two minutes is the entry point; most days you'll do more, but even if you don't, you've won - Define three levels: Minimum (2-min), Target (10-min), Ideal (30-min) - Never zero. Even minimum is a vote for your identity.

***Up next:** You've designed your 2-minute habit. Now it's time to execute. Chapter 4 walks you through your first seven days—what to expect, how to troubleshoot, and how to build the foundation that everything else rests on.*

>

CHAPTER 4 — DAYS 1–7: ESTABLISHING YOUR BASELINE

 **Week-1 Plan:** One habit. One cue. Two minutes. ✓ daily.

The first week is about one thing: **showing up**.

Don't worry about results, intensity, or perfection. Your only job is to fire the loop seven times.

YOUR WEEK-1 MISSION

Pick **one** keystone habit. (A keystone habit is one that creates a ripple effect—exercise, meditation, morning pages, or a daily walk.)

Design your loop:

1. **Cue:** After I __, I will...
2. **Routine:** Do the 2-minute version: _
3. **Reward:** I will feel/do _

Example:

- Cue: After I make my morning coffee
- Routine: Put on workout shoes and do 1 push-up
- Reward: Play my favourite pump-up track + check the wall calendar

WEEK-1 DAILY CHECKLIST

Day	**Did I do the 2-min version?**	**How easy was it? (1-5)**	**Notes**
Monday	☐ Yes		
Tuesday	☐ Yes		
Wednesday	☐ Yes		
Thursday	☐ Yes		
Friday	☐ Yes		
Saturday	☐ Yes		
Sunday	☐ Yes		

WHAT TO EXPECT

Days 1–3: Clunky but doable

You'll feel the friction. Your brain is negotiating: "Do I have to?" The cue might not feel natural yet. The routine might feel silly. That's normal.

Days 4–5: Settling in

The loop starts to feel less foreign. You might catch yourself thinking about the habit before the cue even fires.

Days 6–7: Early wins

Small pride appears. You've shown up all week. That consistency is already rewiring your brain.

CASE STUDY: JAMES'S READING HABIT

 **Background:** James, a software engineer, wanted to read more but hadn't finished a book in 2 years. **First attempt:** "Read 30 minutes before bed." Lasted 2 days. Too tired, kept falling asleep. **The adjustment:** One page after lunch at his desk, with his coffee still warm. **Week 1 results:** - Days 1-2: Felt weird reading at work. Did it anyway. - Day 3: Forgot. Remembered at 3pm, read one page then. - Days 4-7: Hit it every day. Most days read 3-5 pages. **Key insight:** "Tying it to lunch coffee was genius. I already have that habit wired. The book just lives on my desk now, and I don't negotiate."

TROUBLESHOOTING WEEK 1

🦋 "I forgot to do it" → Your cue isn't obvious enough. Add a physical reminder: post-it note, alarm, object placement. "I did it but skipped the reward" → Rewards are not optional. They close the loop. Make it non-negotiable. "I did more than 2 minutes and now I'm sore/tired" → Slow down. You're building the runway. Stick to the minimum for the full first week. "I missed a day" → Fine. **Never zero twice.** Get back on track immediately tomorrow. One miss is data, two is a pattern.

END-OF-WEEK REFLECTION

Answer these three questions on Day 7:

1. Did I hit 5+ days this week?

If yes: You're on track. If no: Your cue or routine needs adjustment.

2. What made it easy on the days I succeeded?

(Look for patterns: time of day, environment, mood)

3. What got in the way on the days I missed?

(This is gold. Design around this obstacle in Week 2.)

 **Warning signs to watch for:** - If ease rating is 1-2 all week → Habit is too big, shrink it - If you missed 3+ days → Cue isn't reliable, anchor it better - If you did the habit but feel drained → Reward isn't working, change it



Chapter 4 Key Takeaways: - Week 1 goal: show up 5-7 days, even if just for 2 minutes - Pick one keystone habit, design the loop (cue + routine + reward) - Track daily with a simple yes/no + ease rating - Troubleshoot immediately if you miss; never zero twice

***Up next:** You've completed your first week. The novelty is about to wear off. Chapter 5 shows you how to use habit stacking and environment design to build consistency when motivation fades.*

>

CHAPTER 5 — DAYS 8–15: BUILDING CONSISTENCY

 **Stack it:** After [existing routine], I will [two-minute habit].

By Week 2, the novelty has worn off. This is where most people stumble. The loop isn't automatic yet, but it's also not exciting anymore.

Your strategy this week: **habit stacking** and **environment design**.

HABIT STACKING: THE CHAINING METHOD

Instead of relying on motivation, chain your new habit to an existing routine. The existing routine becomes the cue.

Formula: After I [EXISTING HABIT], I will [NEW HABIT].

Examples:

- After I pour my morning coffee, I will do 1 push-up.
- After I brush my teeth, I will write one sentence in my journal.
- After I sit down at my desk, I will open my task list and highlight the top 3 priorities.

The existing habit is already wired. You're borrowing its automaticity.

ENVIRONMENT DESIGN: FRICTION ENGINEERING

Make good habits easy:

- **Proximity:** Put tools where the cue happens (book on pillow, shoes by kettle)
- **Visibility:** Make reminders obvious (post-its, calendar on wall)
- **Prep:** Set up the night before (gym clothes laid out, journal open on desk)

Make bad habits hard:

- **Distance:** Move temptations out of sight (phone in another room, biscuits on high shelf)
- **Friction:** Add steps to the bad habit (log out of social media, delete apps)
- **Delay:** Implement a 10-minute rule before giving in

WEEK-2 DAILY TRACKER

Continue your simple tracker. This week, add a column for **ease rating** (1-5 scale).

- 1 = Brutal, had to force it
- 3 = Neutral, did it but with some negotiation
- 5 = Effortless, happened automatically

Watch for the ease rating to climb as the loop wires in.

THE MOTIVATIONAL DIP IS COMING

 **Research shows:** Motivation typically dips around Days 10-18. This is when your brain realizes this isn't a one-time thing—it's permanent. Your prefrontal cortex gets tired. You'll feel resistance. **Solution:** Rely on the system (cue + environment), not motivation.

Expect the dip. Plan for it. Your job is to show up even when it feels hard.

CASE STUDY: PRIYA'S MEDITATION PRACTICE

 **Background:** Priya, a marketing manager, wanted to meditate to manage work stress. **First attempt:** "10 minutes in the morning." Lasted 5 days. Couldn't find time before the kids woke up. **The adjustment:** 3 breaths after dropping kids at school, still sitting in the car before driving to work. **Week 2 challenge:** Day 9—forgot completely. Day 10—almost forgot, but saw her cushion in the passenger seat (she'd moved it there as a reminder). **Result:** Hit 12/14 days in the first two weeks. By week 4, naturally expanded to 5 minutes most days. **Key insight:** "The car became my meditation space. The drive home is my cue. I never thought I'd meditate in a car park, but it works better than any cushion at home."

WORKSHOP: DESIGN YOUR ENVIRONMENT

Pick your habit. Answer these:

What can I place in my environment to make the habit obvious?

What can I prep the night before?

What obstacles can I remove?

What bad habit can I add friction to this week?

⚠ **Warning signs to watch for:** - If you're negotiating every morning → Cue needs to be stronger - If you keep "forgetting" → Environment needs visual reminders - If ease rating is dropping → You may be trying to do too much, return to minimum



Chapter 5 Key Takeaways: - Habit stacking: chain new habit to existing routine - Environment design: reduce friction for good habits, add friction for bad - Expect a motivational dip around Days 10-18; rely on systems, not willpower - Track ease rating (1-5) to monitor progress

***Up next:** You're past the first dip. Week 3 is when the magic starts—the habit begins to feel less like work and more like routine. Chapter 6 shows you how to deepen the groove and start laddering up.*

>

CHAPTER 6 — DAYS 16–23: DEEPENING THE GROOVE

 Lower negotiation cost = wiring taking hold.

By the middle of Week 3, something shifts. The habit starts to feel less like a decision and more like something you just...do.

This week is about **deepening the groove** and starting to **ladder up** in small increments.

THE LADDER: GRADUAL INCREASE

Don't stay at two minutes forever. But don't jump to 30 minutes either.

Week 3 strategy: Add one small increment.

Examples:

- 2 minutes → 3–5 minutes
- 1 push-up → 3 push-ups
- 1 page → 2–3 pages
- 1 sentence → 1 paragraph



Rule of thumb: Increase by no more than 10–25% per week. You're building capacity, not testing limits.

TEMPTATION BUNDLING

Pair your habit with something you enjoy. This makes the craving stronger.

Formula: I will [HABIT I NEED] while [THING I ENJOY].

Examples:

- I will do my stretches while listening to my favourite podcast.
- I will review my budget while drinking my fancy coffee.
- I will walk on the treadmill while watching my guilty-pleasure show.

The enjoyable activity becomes part of the reward, which strengthens the loop.

WHAT "WIRING IN" FEELS LIKE

Early Days (1-10)	**Mid-Phase (11-20)**	**Deepening (21-30)**
High negotiation, high effort	Moderate negotiation, moderate effort	Low negotiation, low effort
"Do I have to?"	"I should do this"	"It's time to do this"
Feels like work	Feels like routine	Feels like identity

You're moving from **discipline** to **system** to **default**.

CASE STUDY: MARCUS'S WRITING PRACTICE

 **Background:** Marcus, a product manager, wanted to write a book but hadn't written creatively in 10 years. **The system:** **One sentence** after his first meeting of the day, before checking Slack again. **Week 3 experience:** - Day 16: Wrote for 15 minutes without noticing. Felt good. - Day 17: Back to one sentence. Busy day. Still counts. - Day 19: Realized he was thinking about his book character during his commute. - Day 21: Wrote 3 paragraphs. The floodgates opened. **Key insight:** "Week 3 was when it stopped being this thing I 'had to do' and became this thing I 'get to do.' The one-sentence rule kept me showing up until my brain caught up with my intentions."

WEEK-3 CHECK-IN

Answer these:

1. Is my habit happening with less internal negotiation?
2. Have I been able to increase the duration/intensity slightly?
3. What's the ease rating trend? (Are 4s and 5s appearing more often?)

If your ease rating is still mostly 1s and 2s by Day 21, your habit might be too ambitious. Shrink it.

 **Warning signs to watch for:** - If ease rating hasn't improved → Habit is still too big OR environment has too much friction - If you're bored → Good sign; it's becoming routine (add slight variability next week) - If you're skipping rewards → You're self-sabotaging; rewards are not optional



Chapter 6 Key Takeaways: - Start laddering up: increase by 10-25% per week - Use temptation bundling to strengthen the craving - Watch for lower negotiation cost—this is wiring taking hold - If ease rating isn't improving by Day 21, shrink the habit

***Up next:** You've made it through three weeks. This is the checkpoint. Chapter 7 walks you through the 30-day debrief and shows you how to lock in your foundation before moving to Phase 2.*

>

CHAPTER 7 — DAYS 24–30: FOUNDATION COMPLETE



Debrief like a pilot, not a judge.

You've made it to the end of Phase 1. Congratulations.

Most people don't get this far.

This week is about **consolidation** and **reflection**. You're locking in the foundation before you build on it.

THE 30-DAY DEBRIEF

Set aside 15 minutes on Day 30. Answer these questions:

Snapshot:

- Total days completed: ____ / 30
- Ease rating trend: (Did it get easier?)
- Current duration/intensity: (How far have you laddered?)

Keep / Change / Kill:

- What's working well that I should keep?
- What needs adjustment (cue, time, environment)?
- What should I stop doing (overthinking, overcomplicating)?

Posture check:

- **Mindset:** Am I being patient and kind to myself, or am I judging every slip?
- **Energy:** Do I feel energized by the habit, or drained?

Guardrails:

- **Minimum:** What's my floor for hard days? (e.g., 3x per week minimum)
- **Maximum:** What's my ceiling to avoid burnout? (e.g., no more than 90 min/day)

COMMON 30-DAY PATTERNS

 **Pattern 1: Strong start, mid-phase dip, recovery** This is normal. The dip usually happens Days 10–20. If you recovered, you're resilient. **Pattern 2: Consistent 80%+ from the start** Excellent. Your habit is well-designed (right size, right cue, right reward). **Pattern 3: Erratic (on/off/on/off)** Your cue isn't reliable, or the habit is still too ambitious. Shrink and anchor better. **Pattern 4: Strong for 2 weeks, then fell off** You hit the dip and didn't recover. Re-examine: Is the habit meaningful to you? Is the cue clear? Is there friction in the environment?

CELEBRATING SMALL WINS

This is important. Your brain needs to feel the win.

Ideas:

- Post your 30-day tracker somewhere visible
- Share your streak with a friend or accountability partner
- Reward yourself with something meaningful (new book, massage, nice meal)
- Write yourself a short note: "I showed up for 30 days. I am someone who [habit]."

IDENTITY SHIFT CHECKPOINT

By Day 30, you should feel a subtle shift. The habit isn't just something you "do"—it's starting to become part of who you "are."

Fill in the blank:

"I am someone who _ daily."

Read it out loud. Does it feel true? Even a little?

If yes: You've successfully wired the identity. This is the foundation everything else builds on.

If no: That's okay. Identity often lags behaviour by 30–60 days. Keep going.

PHASE 1 TOOLKIT: QUICK WIN ARCHIVE

 **Your Phase 1 tools (always available):** ✓ 2-minute rule (LVA) ✓ Cue anchoring (habit stacking) ✓ Environment design (proximity, visibility, prep) ✓ Simple tracking (yes/no + ease rating) ✓ Never zero twice rule ✓ Temptation bundling **If you remember nothing else, remember this:** → Show up even when it's small → Design beats willpower → Never zero twice **Red flags that mean you need to adjust:** ⚠ Ease rating still 1-2 after 3 weeks → Too big ⚠ Missing 3+ days per week → Cue not reliable ⚠ Drained after completing → Wrong reward or wrong habit



Chapter 7 Key Takeaways: - Day 30 debrief: snapshot, keep/change/kill, posture, guardrails - Common patterns: dip in Days 10-20 is normal; recovery is what matters - Celebrate the win—your brain needs to feel it - Identity shift: "I am someone who ____" should start to feel true

***Up next:** Phase 1 is complete. You've built one solid habit. Phase 2 is about expansion—adding complementary habits and stress-testing the system. Chapter 8 shows you how to build your habit ecosystem.*

>

PART TWO: INTEGRATION (DAYS 31–60)

 **You are here: Days 31–60** Goal: Build consistency through disruption and expand your habit ecosystem.

CHAPTER 8 — DAYS 31–45: EXPANDING YOUR HABIT ECOSYSTEM

 Add a **complementary** 2-minute habit. One chain, one reward.

Phase 1 was about establishing **one** rock-solid habit.

Phase 2 is about **expanding the ecosystem**—adding complementary habits that stack together and testing resilience through real-world stress.

THE HABIT ECOSYSTEM

Habits don't exist in isolation. The best ones reinforce each other.

Examples:

- Morning pages → Clarity → Better task prioritization → More productive day
- Exercise → Energy → Better sleep → Earlier wake time → More time for morning pages
- Healthy breakfast → Stable blood sugar → Fewer cravings → Easier to stick to budget

 **Strategy:** Pick a second habit that **supports** your first one, not one that competes for the same time/energy.

ADDING A SECOND HABIT: THE STACKING APPROACH

Don't start from scratch. Stack the new habit onto the existing one.

Formula: After I [HABIT 1], I will [HABIT 2].

Examples:

- After I do my 1 push-up, I will drink a full glass of water.
- After I write my morning sentence, I will review my top 3 priorities for the day.
- After I stretch for 2 minutes, I will sit for 3 breaths (meditation).

The first habit acts as the cue for the second. This creates a **chain**.

HABIT CHAINS: THE POWER OF SEQUENCE

 **The domino effect:**  **Cue** (morning alarm) →  **Habit 1** (1 push-up) →  **Habit 2** (glass of water) →  **Habit 3** (journal sentence) →  **Day started strong** Once the first domino falls, the rest follow automatically.

****Weak Approach****

****Strong Approach (Chain)****

- Drink water at some point
- Journal at some point | Wake up → Coffee → 1 push-up → Glass of water → 1 journal sentence → Day starts |

Three separate decisions, three negotiation points

One trigger, chain reaction, minimal negotiation

 **Warning signs your chain is breaking:** - You're skipping the second habit but doing the first - Gap between habits is too long (more than 5 minutes) - You're negotiating whether to continue mid-chain **Fix:** Shrink both habits to 30-second versions and tighten the sequence

CONTEXT REHEARSAL: PRACTICE PORTABILITY

Your habit works at home. But what about at work? On the road? When life gets chaotic?

This week, rehearse your habit in a second context.

 **Context rehearsal micro-drills:** - **Home:** [Your 2-min version] + [Your cue at home] - **Office:** [Adapted version] + [Your cue at work] - **Travel:** [Minimal version] + [Hotel/car cue] Practice each context at least once before you actually need it.

Examples:

- If you exercise at home in the morning, try a lunchtime version at the office.
- If you journal at your desk, try it in a café or on a park bench.
- If you meditate in your bedroom, try it on the train or at the gym.

The habit becomes resilient when it can fire in multiple environments.

CASE STUDY: SARAH'S MORNING ROUTINE CHAIN

 **Background:** Sarah, a teacher, wanted to feel more grounded before facing 30 students every day. **Phase 1 habit:** 3 deep breaths after alarm, before getting out of bed. **Phase 2 expansion:** Added a glass of water (kept by bed) + one grateful thought. **The chain:** Alarm → 3 breaths → Glass of water (drink while thinking grateful thought) → Feet hit floor. **Week 5 result:** The whole routine takes 90 seconds. But she arrives at school calm, not frantic. Students noticed the shift before she did. **Key insight:** "I never thought 90 seconds could change my whole day. But starting calm compounds. I'm a better teacher because I'm a calmer human."

WEEK 5-6 TRACKER: TWO HABITS

Day	**Habit 1**	**Habit 2**	**Chain completed?**
Day 31			
Day 32			
...			

Track the chain as a unit. The goal is to fire both habits in sequence.

 **Warning signs to watch for:** - If adding Habit 2 breaks Habit 1 → You moved too fast; go back to one habit - If you skip Habit 2 often → It's not stacked correctly; needs stronger cue - If the chain feels exhausting → Too many steps; shrink both to 1-min versions



Chapter 8 Key Takeaways: - Habits are ecosystems; add complementary habits that reinforce each other - Stack the second habit onto the first to create a chain - Rehearse in a second context to build portability - Track the chain as a unit

***Up next:** You're expanding the system. But expansion creates vulnerability. Chapter 9 prepares you for inevitable disruptions and gives you the GBOT Protocol—your recovery playbook for when life gets messy.*

>

CHAPTER 9 — DAYS 46–60: NAVIGATING SETBACKS

🔧 **GBOT Protocol:** Name it → Return to base → Patch the leak → Create If-Then.

By Week 7, you will hit a disruption. Travel. Illness. Work deadline. Family emergency.

This is not a failure. This is the **stress test**. How your habit survives this moment determines whether it lasts.

THE GBOT PROTOCOL (GET BACK ON TRACK)

When you miss a day (or several), follow this four-step recovery:

1. Name it.

Acknowledge the disruption without judgment. "I missed three days because of the work trip."

2. Return to base.

Go back to the **minimum version** immediately. Not the advanced version. The 2-minute version.

3. Patch the leak.

Identify the specific obstacle: time, environment, energy, etc. What broke the loop?

4. Create an if-then plan.

"If [situation], then [minimum version]."

COMMON DISRUPTIONS & IF-THEN PLANS

Disruption	**If-Then Plan**
Travel	If I'm traveling, I'll do a 5-min hotel workout + 1 min journal
Illness	If I'm sick, I'll do 3 deep breaths + drink water (minimum to maintain identity)
Work deadline	If I have a deadline, I'll do the 2-min version during lunch break
Social event	If I have evening plans, I'll do the habit in the morning no matter what
Motivation dip	If I don't feel like it, I'll do exactly 2 minutes and stop

COMPASSION VS. DISCIPLINE

Compassion

- Be kind to yourself when you slip
- Acknowledge setbacks without judgment
- Focus on the next rep, not the missed one

Discipline

- Stick to minimums even when you don't feel like it
- Implement your if-then plans
- Protect your habit time as non-negotiable

💛 **Both are required.** Compassion without discipline becomes permission to quit. Discipline without compassion becomes burnout.

CASE STUDY: DAVID'S BUSINESS TRIP RECOVERY

 **Background:** David, a consultant, had built a 45-day streak of daily push-ups. **The disruption:** Week-long client trip. Missed 4 days straight. Felt like a failure. **GBOT Protocol applied:** 1. **Named it:** "I missed 4 days because of travel chaos and client dinners." 2. **Returned to base:** Day 50—did 1 push-up in the hotel room at 11 PM. 3. **Patched the leak:** "I have no cue when traveling. Morning routine is shot." 4. **Created if-then:** "If I'm traveling, I'll do 1 push-up right after brushing teeth at night." **Result:** Didn't miss another day for the next 40 days. Travel became a context he'd practiced in. **Key insight:** "Missing 4 days didn't break me. It was the data I needed. Now I have a travel plan. I'm actually more confident in my habit now than before the trip."

WEEK 7-8 RESILIENCE TRACKER

Track not just completion, but **how you recovered from misses**.

Day	**Completed?**	**If missed, why?**	**Recovery action**
Day 46	☐		
Day 47	☐		
...			

HABIT PROGRESS DASHBOARD

At the end of Week 8 (Day 60), create a snapshot:

Consistency: ___ / 60 days completed

Capacity: Went from *minutes to* minutes

Resilience: Recovered from ___ disruptions

Key win: _

Biggest challenge: _

PHASE 2 TOOLKIT: QUICK WIN ARCHIVE

 **Your Phase 2 tools (add to Phase 1 toolkit):** ✓ Habit chaining (stack habits in sequence) ✓ Context rehearsal (practice in 2+ environments) ✓ GBOT Protocol (never zero twice with a system) ✓ If-then planning (pre-decide for disruptions) ✓ Resilience tracking (log recovery, not just completion) **If you remember nothing else, remember this:** → Recovery speed > perfection → One miss = data, two misses = pattern → Always return to base (2-min version) **Red flags that mean you need to adjust:** ⚠️ Missing 2+ days in a row → Activate GBOT immediately ⚠️ Can't recover within 24 hours → Habit is too complex ⚠️ Feeling guilty instead of curious → Mindset needs compassion



Chapter 9 Key Takeaways: - Disruptions are the stress test; recovery is what matters - GBOT Protocol: Name it → Base → Patch → If-Then - Balance compassion (kind to yourself) with discipline (stick to minimums) - Track recovery actions, not just completions

Up next: *You've survived disruption. You've built resilience. Phase 3 is about cementing the identity and moving from "doing" to "being." Chapter 10 shows you how to lock in the habit at the identity level.*

>

PART THREE: MASTERY (DAYS 61–90)

 **You are here: Days 61–90** Goal: Shift from "doing" to "being" — make the habit part of who you are.

CHAPTER 10 — DAYS 61–75: IDENTITY REINFORCEMENT

 "I am someone who ____ daily." Then: **Vote cast.**

You've been *doing* the habit for 60 days. Now you're going to shift from **behaviour** to **identity**.

This is where lasting change happens. When the habit becomes part of your self-story.

THE IDENTITY LOCK-IN RITUAL

On Day 61, create an identity card. This is a physical or digital card that states your new identity.

Format:

"I am someone who ____ daily."

>

Examples:

- I am someone who moves daily.
- I am someone who writes daily.
- I am someone who prioritizes my health daily.

Place it somewhere you'll see it every day: fridge, bathroom mirror, phone lock screen, wallet.

 Every time you complete the habit, you're casting a vote for this identity. Every vote makes the story stronger.

THE 5-POINT IDENTITY RITUAL

📄 **Printable Identity Card (A6)** --- I am someone who _____ daily. --- Every time I show up, I cast a vote for this identity. Every vote makes the story stronger. --- Started: Day 1 | Solidified: Day 90

By Day 75, complete these five milestones to "officialize" the identity:

Milestone	**Action**	**Completed?**
1. Logged 60+ days	Check your tracker	☐
2. Shared with a friend	Tell someone about your streak	☐
3. Mini-mastery challenge	Do a slightly advanced version for 3 days straight	☐
4. Environment optimized	All tools in place, zero friction	☐
5. Celebrated progress	Reward yourself meaningfully	☐

WEEKLY 15-MINUTE REVIEWS

From Day 61 onward, do a weekly review every Sunday (or your chosen day).

Format:

1. Snapshot:

Days completed this week: ___ / 7

Ease rating trend: ___

2. Keep / Change / Kill:

● Keep: _

● Change: _

● Kill (stop doing): _

3. Posture:

● Mindset: Growth-focused or judgment-heavy?

● Energy: Energized or drained?

4. Guardrails:

● Minimum: ___ x per week

● Maximum: ___ min per day

5. Identity reinforcement:

Read your identity card. Does it feel true? (It should by now.)



Chapter 10 Key Takeaways: - Shift from behaviour to identity: "I am someone who..." - Create an identity card and place it where you'll see it daily - Complete the 5-point identity ritual by Day 75 - Weekly 15-min reviews keep you calibrated

Up next: *Identity is locked in. Now it's time to cement the habit permanently. Chapter 11 shows you how to automate supports, track metrics, and transition to maintenance mode.*

>

CHAPTER 11 — DAYS 76–90: CEMENTING YOUR NEW REALITY

 Automate supports. Track one leading + one lagging indicator.

The final two weeks are about **cementing** the habit and **preparing for maintenance mode**.

You're moving from active construction to cruise control.

AUTOMATE EVERYTHING YOU CAN

Look for places to reduce friction even further:

Examples:

- **Calendar blocks:** Recurring event for habit time
- **Auto-delivery:** Protein powder, journal refills, workout gear
- **Reminders:** Phone alarm, smart home routine, accountability text
- **Environment upgrades:** Permanent changes (standing desk, water filter, gym membership)

The less you have to think about logistics, the more energy you have for the habit itself.

LEADING VS. LAGGING INDICATORS

By Day 90, track two metrics:

1. Leading indicator (process):

Something you control directly.

- Example: Days per week completed

2. Lagging indicator (outcome):

Something that results from the habit over time.

- Example: Energy level, mood score, fitness benchmark, pages written

Habit	**Leading Indicator**	**Lagging Indicator**
Daily exercise	Days per week completed	Resting heart rate, stamina
Daily writing	Sentences/words written	Pages completed, clarity of thought
Daily meditation	Minutes logged	Stress level, focus duration

Leading indicators tell you if you're showing up. Lagging indicators tell you if it's working.

THE 90-DAY CELEBRATION

On Day 90, pause and recognize what you've done.

Reflection prompts:

- Where was I on Day 1? Where am I now?
- What surprised me about this process?
- What's different in my life because of this habit?
- What identity shift has happened?

Celebration ideas:

- Share your 90-day story with someone who matters
- Post your tracker (physical or digital) somewhere permanent
- Give yourself a meaningful reward (not junk, something that honours the effort)
- Write a letter to your future self: "Here's what I did, and here's how I'll maintain it."

CELEBRATION RITUALS LIBRARY

Type	**Ideas**
Solo	Special meal, massage, new gear, day trip, museum visit, concert
Social	Share the story at dinner, post progress photos, accountability partner celebration call
Symbolic	Frame your tracker, buy identity-affirming item (runner's watch, writer's desk), get a tattoo
Experiential	Take a class in the habit (yoga retreat, writing workshop), join a community
Legacy	Write a letter to future you, create a "lessons learned" document, mentor someone starting out

PREPARING FOR MAINTENANCE MODE

You've built the habit. Now you need to maintain it without constant attention.

Transition checklist:

- ☐ All automation in place (reminders, calendar, environment)
- ☐ If-then plans for common disruptions documented
- ☐ Monthly review scheduled (replace weekly reviews with monthly)
- ☐ Identity statement feels true
- ☐ Habit is portable (works in multiple contexts)



Chapter 11 Key Takeaways: - Automate everything: calendar, reminders, environment upgrades - Track one leading (process) + one lagging (outcome) indicator - Celebrate Day 90 meaningfully - Transition to maintenance mode with monthly reviews

Up next: *You've completed the 90 days. Chapter 12 shows you how to maintain forever—with minimal effort and maximum reliability.*

>

CHAPTER 12 — MAINTENANCE MODE: MAKING IT LAST FOREVER

∞ Maintenance = reliability with minimal attention.

The 90-day program is complete. But the habit isn't "done."

Now you enter **maintenance mode**—keeping the habit alive with the least amount of effort.

THE MAINTENANCE MODE MINDSET

Maintenance is not about perfection. It's about **reliability with flexibility**.

What changes:

- Daily tracking → Weekly check-ins
- Active building → Passive maintenance
- High focus → Background routine

What stays:

- Never zero twice rule
- If-then plans for disruptions
- Identity reinforcement
- Environment designed for ease

MAINTENANCE TRIGGERS: WHEN TO INTERVENE

You don't need daily attention. But watch for these triggers:

Trigger	**Maintenance Response**
Missed 2 days in a row	Return to base (2-min version) immediately
Ease rating drops below 3 for a week	Environment audit: What friction appeared?
Boredom / plateau	Add slight variability (new routine, new context)
Major life change (move, job, etc.)	Rehearse in new context; update if-then plans

THE QUARTERLY REVIEW

Every 90 days, do a full review:

1. Snapshot:

- Consistency over last 90 days: ____ %

- Current capacity: ____ (duration/intensity)

- Key wins: _

2. Keep / Change / Kill:

- What's still working?

- What needs adjustment?

- What should I stop doing?

3. Habit portfolio:

- Core habits (daily, non-negotiable): ____

- Seasonal habits (project sprints, 30-day experiments): ____

- Experimental habits (testing, might drop): ____

4. Next 90 days:

- Same habit, deeper mastery?

- Add a new complementary habit?

- Take a maintenance break and focus elsewhere?

THE HABIT PORTFOLIO

By now, you've built one habit to mastery. Over time, you'll build more.

Think of your habits in tiers:

Tier	**Description**	**Examples**
Core	Daily essentials. Always active.	Movement, hydration, sleep routine
Seasonal	90-day projects or focus areas.	Writing sprint, reading challenge, workout program
Experimental	Testing new habits. Might keep or drop.	Cold showers, gratitude journal, language learning

Not every habit needs to last forever. Some serve a season.

PERMANENT ENVIRONMENT UPGRADES

By now, you should have made these changes permanent:

Proximity:

Tools live where the habit happens

Visibility:

Reminders in your field of view

Friction:

Bad habits are hard; good habits are easy

Default:

The path of least resistance is the right path

MAINTENANCE MODE CHECKLIST

 **You're in maintenance mode when:** - ☐ The habit happens most days without negotiation - ☐ You have automated reminders and environment supports - ☐ If-then plans exist for all common disruptions - ☐ You do monthly (not daily) reviews - ☐ The habit feels like part of your identity - ☐ You can explain the habit to someone else clearly

FINAL WORDS

You didn't need more willpower. You needed better design.

You didn't need to be "disciplined." You needed loops that made the right action easy and obvious.

And you didn't need a perfect streak. You just needed to **never zero twice**.



You don't need fireworks. You need quiet proof. Keep the loops small, the cues loud, and the wins easy to feel. You've built the system. Now let it run.



Chapter 12 Key Takeaways: - Maintenance = reliability with flexibility - Watch for triggers (2 missed days, low ease rating, boredom) - Quarterly reviews replace weekly reviews - Build a habit portfolio: Core, Seasonal, Experimental - You're in maintenance when the habit is automatic and identity-level

BONUS: CHAPTER 13 — ADVANCED TECHNIQUES



For those ready to build habit mastery at scale.

HABIT CHAINING AT SCALE: MORNING & EVENING ROUTINES

Once you've mastered individual habits, you can build **complete routines** that chain 5-10 habits in sequence.

Example morning routine:

Wake → Bathroom → Weight (track) → Glass of water → 5 push-ups → 3 breaths → Journal 1 sentence → Review top 3 priorities → Coffee → Day starts

The key: Each step cues the next. No decisions between steps.

SEASONAL HABIT ROTATION

Not every habit needs to run year-round. Strategic rotation prevents burnout.

Example:

- **Q1:** Writing focus (daily 500 words)
- **Q2:** Fitness focus (daily movement + meal prep)
- **Q3:** Learning focus (daily language practice)
- **Q4:** Reflection focus (daily journaling + weekly reviews)

Core habits (sleep, hydration) stay constant. Everything else rotates.

HABIT PAIRING FOR COUPLES/FAMILIES

Building habits together creates accountability and shared identity.

Strategies:

- **Parallel habits:** Both do the same habit at the same time (morning walk together)
- **Complementary habits:** Each does a different habit that supports the household (one cooks, one preps)
- **Accountability rituals:** Weekly check-in where you share progress and troubleshoot together

TRAVEL-PROOFING YOUR HABITS

Travel is the #1 habit killer. Here's how to make your habits portable:

1. Create hotel/travel versions

- Push-ups → Can be done in any room
- Running → Can be done anywhere with shoes
- Journaling → Digital version on phone

2. Pack trigger objects

- Resistance band, yoga mat, journal

3. Pre-decide the cue

- "After I brush teeth in hotel bathroom"
- "Before I leave hotel room for breakfast"

THE 1% RULE: COMPOUND TINY GAINS

If you improve by just 1% each day, you'll be 37x better in a year.

How to apply:

- Week 1-4: 2 minutes daily
- Week 5-8: 2.5 minutes daily (+25%)
- Week 9-12: 3 minutes daily (+20%)
- Continue this gentle growth for a year

By Day 365, your "2-minute habit" is now 20+ minutes, but it never felt like a jump.

WHAT IF: SPECIAL SITUATIONS



Real questions from real people.

What if I have ADHD?

- **Shorten everything.** 2 minutes might still be too long. Try 30 seconds.
- **Use alarms relentlessly.** Your phone is your external prefrontal cortex.
- **Pair with dopamine.** Temptation bundling is your best friend.
- **Body-doubling works.** Do the habit while on a call with a friend or accountability partner.

What if I work shifts?

- **Anchor to actions, not times.** "After I get home" instead of "at 7 AM."
- **Build multiple if-then plans.** One for day shifts, one for night shifts.
- **Track weekly, not daily.** Aim for 5/7 days, not a perfect streak.

What if I have young kids?

- **Habit-stack onto kid routines.** "While kids eat breakfast, I do 1 push-up."
- **Accept interruptions.** Your minimum might be 15 seconds some days. That still counts.
- **Use naptime or bedtime.** But don't rely on it being consistent.
- **Partner up.** Take turns covering each other's habit time.

What if I travel constantly?

- **Build portable habits.** Bodyweight exercise, digital journal, meditation app.
- **Use hotel rooms as labs.** Practice the habit in different environments from the start.
- **Make travel the cue.** "When I check into a hotel, I do X immediately."

COMMON HABIT RECIPES

 **Ready-to-use blueprints.** Pick one and start today.

RECIPE 1: MORNING MOVEMENT (FOR DESK WORKERS)

Cue: After making coffee

2-min version: Put on shoes + 1 push-up

Target: 10-min bodyweight circuit

Reward: Favorite morning track + check calendar

Common obstacles:

- "I'm too tired" → Do 1 push-up in pajamas, then decide
- "No time" → Set alarm 5 min earlier, or do at lunch

If-then plan: If mornings are chaos, I'll do 2 min during lunch break

RECIPE 2: EVENING WIND-DOWN (FOR BETTER SLEEP)

Cue: After brushing teeth

2-min version: 3 deep breaths + dim lights

Target: 10-min stretch + journal + tea

Reward: Soft blanket + calm music

Common obstacles:

- "I get distracted by phone" → Phone in other room by 9 PM
- "Kids need me" → Do after they're asleep, not before

If-then plan: If kids wake up, I'll do 3 breaths and resume after

RECIPE 3: CREATIVE PRACTICE (WRITING/ART/MUSIC)

Cue: After first meeting/email check

2-min version: Write/sketch/play 1 sentence/line/bar

Target: 30 min of flow

Reward: Special coffee + share progress with friend

Common obstacles:

- "Blank page paralysis" → Write literally anything, even "I don't know what to write"
- "Perfectionism" → Set timer, allow yourself to create badly

If-then plan: If I can't focus, I'll do 1 sentence and walk away

RECIPE 4: MINDFUL MORNINGS (FOR ANXIOUS STARTERS)

Cue: Alarm goes off

2-min version: 3 breaths before feet hit floor

Target: 10-min meditation + gratitude

Reward: Calm start + glass of water

Common obstacles:

- "I hit snooze" → Phone across room forces you up
- "Mind races" → That's normal, just breathe

If-then plan: If I'm running late, I'll do 3 breaths in the car

RECIPE 5: FINANCIAL WELLNESS (FOR BUDGET-CONSCIOUS)

Cue: After lunch

2-min version: Log one expense in app

Target: Weekly budget review (15 min)

Reward: See savings grow + treat yourself once/month

Common obstacles:

- "I forget" → Receipt in wallet = cue to log
- "Too tedious" → Use app with photo receipt scan

If-then plan: If I miss a day, I'll log 3 expenses the next day

RECIPE 6: READING PRACTICE

Cue: During commute / lunch / before bed

2-min version: Read 1 page

Target: 30 min daily

Reward: Progress toward "books read this year" goal

Common obstacles:

- "Phone is more appealing" → Book app on phone, delete social media
- "Forget book" → Keep book in bag/car/desk

If-then plan: If I finish a book and don't have next one, I'll read articles

RECIPE 7: RELATIONSHIP CONNECTION (FOR BUSY COUPLES)

Cue: After dinner

2-min version: Ask "How was your day?" + actually listen

Target: 15-min conversation without phones

Reward: Deeper connection + shared evening ritual

Common obstacles:

- "Too tired to talk" → Just do 2 min, quality over quantity
- "Kids interrupt" → Do after kids asleep, or include them

If-then plan: If we're both exhausted, we'll sit in silence together for 2 min

RECIPE 8: LEARNING (LANGUAGE/SKILL)

Cue: While waiting (coffee, commute, queue)

2-min version: 1 flashcard or 1 lesson module

Target: 15 min daily practice

Reward: Streak counter + monthly treat

Common obstacles:

- "App isn't open" → Put app on home screen
- "Lose streak and quit" → Never zero twice

If-then plan: If I miss, I'll do 2 sessions the next day

APPENDIX: TOOLS & TEMPLATES

 Everything you need in one place.

MASTER 90-DAY TRACKER (BLANK TEMPLATE)

Week	**Mon**	**Tue**	**Wed**	**Thu**	**Fri**	**Sat**	**Sun**	**Total**
1								__/7
2-13	Copy this row 12 more times...							

HABIT DESIGN WORKSHEET (CONSOLIDATED)

My habit: ____

Why it matters: ____

Phase 1 (Days 1-30): Design

● Cue: After I ____, I will...

● 2-min version: ____

● Reward: ____

● Environment setup: ____

Phase 2 (Days 31-60): Build

● Second habit to stack: ____

● If-then plan: ____

● Alternate context: ____

Phase 3 (Days 61-90): Lock-in

● Identity statement: "I am someone who ____"

● Automation: ____

● Leading indicator: ____

● Lagging indicator: ____

TROUBLESHOOTING FLOWCHART

...

START: Did I miss the habit?

↓

NO → Great! Keep going.

YES → How many days missed?

↓

1 day → Return to 2-min version immediately. Never zero twice.

2+ days → GBOT Protocol:

1. Name the disruption
2. Return to base (2-min version)
3. Patch the leak (identify obstacle)
4. Create if-then plan

↓

Back on track?

YES → Continue

NO → Is the habit too big? Shrink it.

Is the cue weak? Anchor better.

Is the reward missing? Add one.

...

GLOSSARY OF TERMS

LVA (Lowest Viable Action): The smallest possible version of a habit that still counts as doing it. Usually 2 minutes or less.

Cue stacking / Habit stacking: Anchoring a new habit to an existing routine. "After I [existing habit], I will [new habit]."

GBOT Protocol: Get Back On Track. Four-step recovery process: Name it → Base → Patch → If-Then.

Temptation bundling: Pairing a habit you need with something you enjoy. "I will [habit] while [enjoyable activity]."

Leading indicator: A metric you control directly (days completed, minutes logged).

Lagging indicator: An outcome that results over time (weight loss, pages written, energy level).

Never zero twice: The core rule. Missing one day is data. Missing two days is a pattern. Always return after one miss.

If-then plan: Pre-decision for disruptions. "If [situation], then [minimum version]."

Context rehearsal: Practicing a habit in multiple environments to build portability.

Identity ritual: A practice that reinforces your new self-story. "I am someone who ____."

RESOURCES & FURTHER READING

Books:

- *Atomic Habits* by James Clear
- *The Power of Habit* by Charles Duhigg
- *Tiny Habits* by BJ Fogg
- *Indistractable* by Nir Eyal

Apps:

- Habit tracking: Streaks, Habitica, Loop Habit Tracker
- Meditation: Headspace, Calm, Insight Timer
- Productivity: Notion, Todoist, Things

Communities:

- r/theXeffect (Reddit)
- Habit-building Discord servers
- Local accountability groups (Meetup)

Research:

- Lally et al. (2010) - How long to form a habit
- Wood & Neal (2007) - Habits in everyday life
- Duckworth et al. (2011) - Self-control and habits

🎉 **You have everything you need.** The system is simple. The execution is the work. Start with one habit. Show up for 90 days. Trust the process. Your loops are waiting.

PRINTABLES PACK

 **Download these for offline use** Print, laminate, stick to your fridge. Make them work for you.

NEVER ZERO TWICE — MINI BADGE

 **NEVER ZERO TWICE** One miss = data Two misses = pattern Always return after one.

🔧 GBOT PROTOCOL CARD (ONE-PAGER)

🔧 **GET BACK ON TRACK (GBOT) PROTOCOL** When you miss a day (because you will): **1. NAME IT** "I missed because of ____" (no judgment, just facts) **2. RETURN TO BASE** Do the 2-minute version RIGHT NOW **3. PATCH THE LEAK** What broke the loop? ☐ Wrong time ☐ Weak cue ☐ Environment friction ☐ Energy crash ☐ Disruption (travel/illness/deadline) **4. CREATE IF-THEN** "If [situation], then [minimum version]" Write it down: _____ --- **Recovery speed > perfection**

IDENTITY CARD (A6 — PRINT & LAMINATE)

 **MY IDENTITY CARD** --- I am someone who _____ **daily.** --- Every time I show up, I cast a vote for this identity. Every vote makes the story stronger. --- Started: Day ____ | Solidified: Day 90 --- Current streak: ____ days
Longest streak: ____ days Total completions: ____ / 90

**MASTER 90-DAY TRACKER (PRINTABLE)**

 **Instructions:** Print this page. Mark ✓ for each day completed. Aim for 72+ checks (80%).

Week	**Mon**	**Tue**	**Wed**	**Thu**	**Fri**	**Sat**	**Sun**	**Total**
1	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
2	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
4	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
6	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
7	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
8	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
9	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
10	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
11	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
12	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
13	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	__/7
TOTAL								**___/91**



HABIT DESIGN WORKSHEET (PRINTABLE)

My habit: _____

Why it matters: _____

PHASE 1 (Days 1-30): DESIGN

☐ Cue: After I _____, I will...

☐ 2-min version: _____

☐ Reward: _____

☐ Environment setup: _____

PHASE 2 (Days 31-60): BUILD

☐ Second habit to stack: _____

☐ If-then plan: _____

☐ Alternate context: _____

PHASE 3 (Days 61-90): LOCK-IN

☐ Identity statement: "I am someone who _____"

☐ Automation: _____

☐ Leading indicator: _____

☐ Lagging indicator: _____



TROUBLESHOOTING FLOWCHART (PRINTABLE)

↓ **START: Did I miss the habit?** **NO** → Great! Keep going. **YES** → How many days missed? **1 day** → **Never zero twice** → Return to 2-min version immediately **2+ days** → **GBOT Protocol** 1. Name the disruption 2. Return to base (2-min version) 3. Patch the leak (identify obstacle) 4. Create if-then plan **Back on track?** **YES** → Continue **NO** → Troubleshoot: ☐ Is the habit too big? → Shrink it ☐ Is the cue weak? → Anchor better ☐ Is the reward missing? → Add one

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